

VIKING ARMOUR

Viking warriors' attire varied from the very basic to the more comprehensively kitted out. The poorer Viking would have had to make do with a protective garment of padded leather, although reindeer hide was reputedly even more effective than chainmail. Chainmail was very labour-intensive to make, particularly if individually riveted. It was also extremely heavy, but very difficult to penetrate. Helmets took immense skill to make, and these were fashioned in various styles, one of which was the spectacled helm. However, the popular image of the horned or winged Viking helmet is a fiction.

Gjermundbu helm
The cheek flaps of this typical helmet, also called a spectacled helm, were sometimes tied against the head, perhaps giving rise to the idea of winged or horned Viking helmets.

Four steel plates riveted together by metal strips

Chainmail for neck protection

Hinged, fur-lined cheek flaps

Holes for leather ties to fasten flaps under the chin, or against the helm

Undertunic of unbleached linen

Undertunic and padded top
Undertunics were sometimes worn alone by poorer Vikings. The padded top had two layers of leather stuffed with horsehair. It was buckled at the back to prevent arrows piercing between fastenings.

Stitches in sections to prevent the stuffing from shifting





Conical helm secured with strap



Sax worn across the waist



Sword worn at the left side